

Sta es DELHI

SHEILA DIKSHIT'S
WINNING HAND

YASBANT NEGI

The Rise and Rise of Mrs D

After her historic win, Sheila Dikshit emerges as the tallest leader in the Congress, the Gandhis apart. It wasn't the party's appeal but her tenacity that won the capital.

| By Priya Sahgal |

This lady is not for turning. Like Britain's formidable Mrs T, Sheila Dikshit has woken up often to read her political obituary. Not only the opposition BJP, even her own colleagues in the Congress had written off a comeback for Dikshit in the recent polls. When the results poured in, her granddaughter Tara rushed to hug her saying, "You've done it once again *Dadi*". Actually she has done it twice. This was the third consecutive win for the chief minister as she retained the capital for the Congress. When someone commented that this was a good hat-trick, she replied, "Good or bad. It's a hat-trick."

And no one can call it any different. In 2003, after she won Delhi for the Congress for a second term, Dikshit was made to wait for almost 48 hours before being declared the chief minister. Now, the Congress leadership dare not repeat the affront. The victory is more Dikshit's than her

party's. "I have met the Congress president and sought her blessings," she said. Understandably, the blessings were given promptly this time around.

In the alphabetic power soup of the Congress, after Mrs G and son, Mrs D stands tallest. Even before Delhi declared itself in her favour, she was in demand to campaign in Rajasthan. Now her turf will extend further. The Dikshits share three generations of rapport with the Gandhis—her father-in-law Uma Shankar Dikshit was a member of Indira Gandhi's cabinet while son Sandeep is the East Delhi MP. Her loyalty has never been in doubt—it was Sonia's unstinted support that helped her weather many attempted coups. Now that she has delivered the capital for the Congress, her position is even more secure. Sensing the making of a leader, various general secretaries and chief ministers called to congratulate her. But Dikshit